

Haligric Research Integration Series

PUEBLO PEOPLES

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

American Southwest -- Kiva, Kachina, Shalako, Corn Dance, Blue Lake, and the Oldest Continuously Inhabited Community in North America

"The rain comes because the ceremony is done correctly.

The ceremony is done correctly because the people remember who they are.

The people remember who they are because the kiva is still open."

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A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Pueblo Sovereignty

The Pueblo peoples maintain one of the most carefully protected bodies of sacred knowledge in any Indigenous tradition. Many Pueblo communities distinguish explicitly between what may be shared publicly and what is held as sacred community property -- the specific prayers, the specific songs, the specific ceremonial content of the most sacred ceremonies are not appropriate to document outside the community. This document presents what Pueblo cultural representatives, scholars working with tribal permission, and publicly available tribal sources have shared. The specific content of restricted ceremonies is not included. Photography of most Pueblo ceremonies is prohibited. The sacredness of these restrictions is honored.

Introduction -- Who the Pueblo Peoples Are

The Pueblo peoples are the Indigenous nations of the American Southwest who live in permanent masonry or adobe villages (pueblos -- from the Spanish word for town, applied by Spanish colonizers to describe the multi-story stone and adobe settlements they encountered). Today there are 19 officially recognized Pueblo nations in New Mexico and one -- Hopi -- in Arizona (covered in the dedicated Hopi document). Despite sharing the pueblo architectural tradition and many cultural features, the Pueblo peoples are not a single nation -- they speak languages from at least four distinct language families (Tanoan, Keresan, Zuni, and Hopi) and maintain distinct cultural and ceremonial traditions. The Pueblo peoples are some of the longest continuously inhabiting peoples in North America -- Acoma Pueblo has been inhabited since approximately 1150 CE.

The geographic territory of the Pueblo peoples is the Colorado Plateau and the Rio Grande corridor of the American Southwest -- a landscape of extreme aridity, dramatic mesa formations, and the specific ecology that shaped the Pueblo relationship with water, corn, and the spirit world that governs both. The Pueblo relationship with water is not merely practical -- it is the central theological fact of Pueblo sacred life. In a desert landscape where rain is the difference between life and death for agricultural communities, the ceremonial system that maintains the community's relationship with the rain-bringing spirits is not supplementary to survival -- it is survival.

The Eastern Pueblos -- Rio Grande Traditions

The Eastern Pueblos along the Rio Grande corridor -- Taos, Picuris, Ohkay Owingeh (San Juan), Santa Clara, San Ildefonso, Nambe, Tesuque, Pojoaque, Cochiti, Santo Domingo, San Felipe, Santa Ana, Zia, Jemez, Sandia, and Isleta -- developed specific strategies for preserving their sacred traditions under sustained Spanish colonial pressure from 1598 onward. These strategies included: the incorporation of Catholic ceremonial forms as an outer layer that was publicly performed for Spanish administrators, while the kiva-based traditional ceremonies continued below (sometimes literally, in the underground kivas). This double religious life was not hypocrisy -- it was survival technology. The Pueblo peoples' capacity to maintain their sacred traditions for 400 years of colonial contact while appearing sufficiently Christian to satisfy colonial authorities is one of the most sophisticated examples of sacred cultural resistance in North American history.

Zuni (A:shiwi): Located in western New Mexico, Zuni is the largest single-village Pueblo with approximately 10,000 members. The Zuni language is a language isolate -- like Basque in Europe and Tonkawa in Texas, Zuni has no known linguistic relatives -- reflecting the deep-time presence of A:shiwi people in their territory. The Zuni sacred tradition is organized around the Kachina (Koko) spirit world, the elaborate ceremony of the Shalako (described

below), and the specific sacred arts of pottery, jewelry, and weaving that express the tradition's theological vocabulary in material form.

The Ancestral Puebloans -- The Deep History

The ancestors of the contemporary Pueblo peoples -- long called "Anasazi" in popular literature but now more accurately referred to as Ancestral Puebloans -- built some of the most sophisticated communities in pre-Columbian North America. Chaco Canyon in northwestern New Mexico (occupied from approximately 850-1150 CE) was the center of a regional complex of roads, communication systems, and ceremonial sites that influenced the entire Colorado Plateau. The great houses of Chaco -- particularly Pueblo Bonito, which contained over 600 rooms and may have served as a ceremonial center rather than a primarily residential community -- demonstrate a level of architectural and organizational sophistication that continues to challenge archaeological understanding.

The specific reasons for the abandonment of the great Chacoan complex around 1150 CE remain debated -- prolonged drought is a primary factor, but population pressure, resource depletion, and social disruption also likely contributed. What is not debated is that the descendants of the Ancestral Puebloans are the contemporary Pueblo peoples, whose sacred traditions carry continuity with the ceremonial life of Chaco and Mesa Verde. The specific astronomical alignments of Pueblo Bonito and other Chacoan structures -- oriented to specific solar and lunar events with precision that required sustained observation over generations -- reflect the same sophisticated sacred calendar that contemporary Pueblo ceremonies maintain.

The Pueblo Revolt of 1680 -- The Most Successful Indigenous Uprising

The Pueblo Revolt of 1680 is the most successful Indigenous uprising against European colonialism in the history of North America -- the only instance in which an Indigenous people succeeded in permanently expelling European colonizers from their territory (for 12 years) and negotiating the terms of their return. The Revolt was fundamentally a religious revolution -- a resistance to the Spanish suppression of Pueblo sacred traditions. Spanish colonial authorities systematically suppressed Pueblo sacred practices from 1598 onward: kiva ceremonies were forbidden, sacred masks and ceremonial objects were burned, and Pueblo religious leaders were whipped, hanged, or enslaved for practicing their traditions.

Pope (also called Po'pay) -- a Tewa-speaking Pueblo man from Ohkay Owingeh (San Juan Pueblo) -- organized the most politically sophisticated Indigenous uprising in North American history. Working from Taos Pueblo, he coordinated simultaneous uprisings across all 19 pueblos -- speaking at least six different languages, representing genuinely distinct political communities -- scheduled for August 11, 1680. On August 10 (moved up one day when the Spanish discovered the plan), the Pueblo peoples rose simultaneously across New Mexico, killing approximately 400 Spanish colonists and 21 of the 33 Franciscan missionaries. The surviving Spanish fled south to El Paso del Norte. The 12-year period of freedom that followed saw the complete restoration of Pueblo sacred life. When the Spanish returned in 1692 under Diego de Vargas, the terms were effectively different -- the most aggressive suppression of Pueblo sacred practice did not resume. The Revolt was the specific historical reason that Pueblo sacred traditions survived.

Pueblo Cosmology -- The Emergence and the Four Worlds

The foundational cosmological narrative of the Pueblo peoples (varying in specific details among the different language groups) describes a journey of emergence -- the ancestors' ascent through a series of underworlds to reach the present world through a sipapu (emergence hole). This emergence narrative is not merely a creation story -- it is the

cosmological framework that organizes all of Pueblo ceremonial life. Every kiva contains a sipapu -- the small hole in the floor representing the emergence point. Every ceremony conducted in the kiva is a renewal of the original emergence: the people descending into the below-world relationship, conducting their sacred work in that relationship, and emerging back into the ordinary world changed by what happened below.

The four worlds of the Pueblo emergence narrative correspond to the four directions and to specific sacred qualities that the people acquired or developed in each world. The specific content of the emergence narrative varies among the Pueblo peoples -- Zuni, Hopi, and the various Tanoan and Keresan groups each have their own versions -- but the core structure is shared: the ancestors came from below, emerged through the earth, and were placed in their specific territory by the sacred beings who organized the world. The ongoing maintenance of right relationship with those sacred beings through specific ceremonies is the specific obligation that the emergence placed on the Pueblo peoples.

The Kachina Tradition in Pueblo Peoples

The Kachina (spelled Katsina in Hopi; Koko in Zuni) are the sacred spirit beings who serve as intermediaries between the Pueblo peoples and the divine forces that govern rain, fertility, and the conditions of life. While the dedicated Hopi document covers the Kachina tradition in full detail for that specific community, the Kachina tradition is shared across multiple Pueblo peoples with variations in specific forms and specific spirits. Key elements shared across Pueblo Kachina traditions: the Kachina are associated with the ancestral spirits of the deceased who have joined the spirit world and who return to the living community in specific ceremonies; the Kachina are represented by specific masked figures (tihu -- the carved Kachina dolls -- are educational objects used to teach children to recognize the specific Kachinas); the Kachina ceremonies are primarily connected to the rain cycle and the agricultural calendar; and the Kachinas are invoked through specific ceremonies conducted in the kivas and expressed in the public plaza dances that the broader community participates in.

The Kiva -- The Sacred Underground Chamber, Complete Protocol

The kiva is the most distinctive and most sacred architectural element of Pueblo culture -- a semi-subterranean circular chamber that serves as the community's primary ceremonial space, as the men's social gathering place, and as the specific spatial expression of the Pueblo cosmological understanding of the below-world from which the people emerged. The kiva is underground (or substantially sunken below grade) because the earth's interior is the domain of the sacred beings, of the ancestors, and of the sources of rain and fertility. Entering the kiva through the hatchway in the roof (and descending by ladder) is the specific physical act of entering the sacred dimension.

The kiva's essential elements: the sipapu (the small hole in the floor representing the emergence point, always present as the kiva's most sacred architectural feature); the fire pit (the sacred fire maintained during ceremonies); the deflector stone (placed between the sipapu and the fire pit to protect the sipapu from the fire's draft); the ventilator shaft (providing fresh air and creating the specific circulation pattern that maintains the sacred space); the ladder (the entry/exit point, often with the upper portion projecting through the roof hatch, representing the axis mundi connecting the below-world and the above-world); and the benches around the perimeter (where participants sit during ceremonies). The specific protocols for entering and using the kiva are community-specific and not detailed publicly; the general understanding is that the kiva requires the same quality of attention and specific protocol as any approach to a sacred place.

Zuni -- The Shalako Ceremony, Step-by-Step

The Shalako ceremony -- held in late November or early December at Zuni Pueblo -- is one of the most elaborate and most theologically complete ceremonial events in any Indigenous tradition. It is the culmination of the Zuni sacred year: the annual return of the Shalako (giant bird messengers of the rain gods, represented by 10-foot costumed figures) to bless newly built homes and to renew the community's relationship with the spirit world. The timing is set by the Pekwin (the Zuni Sun Priest) based on his astronomical observations of the winter solstice and the specific position of the Pleiades -- announced approximately a year in advance.

Year-Long Preparation: The families who will host the Shalako figures in their homes must complete or expand those homes to accommodate the 10-foot figures, produce specific quantities of food for the feast, and undertake specific ceremonial obligations throughout the preparation year.

Step 1 -- The Return of the Council of the Gods: The ceremony begins with the return of specific supernatural figures -- including Sayaykia (the warrior) and the Salimopiya (guardian figures) -- who enter the village from the sacred directions.

Step 2 -- The Arrival of the Shalako: At nightfall, six Shalako figures (giant bird messengers, approximately 10 feet tall, operated by Zuni men inside the costume) emerge from the Zuni River and enter the village -- crossing a footbridge between the spirit world and the human world.

Step 3 -- The All-Night Ceremony: Each Shalako figure enters a specific host house and performs the all-night ceremony -- dancing, reciting the entire Zuni cosmological and historical narrative (which can take hours), blessing the house and its occupants.

Step 4 -- The Dawn: At dawn, the Shalako figures emerge from the houses and perform specific ceremonies in the open, before departing the village and crossing back across the footbridge to the spirit world.

Step 5 -- The Foot Race: Following the Shalako's departure, Zuni men run a foot race -- the specific physical ceremony of human vitality that closes the sacred gathering.

Acoma -- Sky City and the Living Tradition

Acoma Pueblo (Haaku) -- called Sky City -- is a mesa-top pueblo approximately 357 feet above the surrounding valley floor in western New Mexico, inhabited since approximately 1150 CE. Acoma is recognized as the oldest continuously inhabited community in the United States. Its position on the mesa was both a defensive strategy and a sacred statement: the community lives closer to the sky world than to the ground. The conquest of Acoma by Juan de Onate in January 1599 was one of the most brutal acts of Spanish colonial violence in North America -- approximately 800 Acoma people were killed and 500 taken prisoner, with every male survivor over 25 having one foot amputated. Acoma rebuilt. The community on the mesa has been continuously inhabited from that point to the present. Approximately 250-300 people live on the mesa year-round today; the broader Acoma Nation numbers approximately 5,000 people. The Spanish colonial church of San Estevan del Rey, built on top of the mesa using Acoma labor in the 1640s, stands alongside traditional kivas -- the same coexistence of Catholic and traditional sacred forms that characterizes much of the Pueblo world.

Taos Pueblo -- The Two-House Sacred Community

Taos Pueblo is a UNESCO World Heritage Site -- one of the oldest and most visually distinctive of all the Pueblo communities, organized around two massive multi-story adobe structures (North House and South House, called Hlauuma and Hlaukwima) divided by the Rio Pueblo de Taos and containing approximately 150 year-round residents who live without modern utilities (no electricity, no running water) to maintain the community's sacred

character. The Taos Pueblo tribal population is approximately 4,500 enrolled members; the Pueblo's tribal lands cover 95,000 acres. The most important sacred site of Taos Pueblo -- Blue Lake (Ba Whyea), high in the Sangre de Cristo Mountains above the pueblo -- is the specific location of the Taos emergence narrative and the site of the most important ceremonies, including an annual pilgrimage. Its restoration in 1970 after a 64-year struggle is the defining contemporary event in Taos Pueblo's sacred history.

Blue Lake and Water as Sacred -- The Return of Sacred Territory

In 1906, President Theodore Roosevelt declared Blue Lake and the surrounding 48,000 acres of Taos Pueblo's sacred mountain territory part of the U.S. National Forest System -- without the Taos Pueblo's consent and in violation of their sacred relationship with the lake. For 64 years, the Taos Pueblo fought for the return of Blue Lake -- through legal processes, through congressional lobbying, through sustained advocacy that involved multiple generations of Taos leaders. On December 15, 1970, President Richard Nixon signed legislation returning the 48,000 acres including Blue Lake to the Taos Pueblo -- the single most significant Indigenous land return in American history. Nixon stated: "This is a bill that represents justice, because in 1906 an injustice was done."

The sacred significance of the victory: for the Taos Pueblo, Blue Lake is not merely a beautiful natural landmark -- it is the specific sacred site from which the Taos people emerged and to which they return in their most important annual ceremony. "The story of my people and the story of this place are one single story. No man can think of us without also thinking of this place. We are always joined together." The return of Blue Lake established a legal and political precedent for sacred land return that influenced Indigenous land rights cases for decades afterward. In 1996, an additional 764 acres were returned to Taos Pueblo.

HALIGRIC LENS: Blue Lake is the most complete available example in North American law of the principle that the Haligric tradition holds about the relationship between a sacred community and its sacred places: the lake and the people are not two things in a relationship -- they are one thing that has two aspects, a human aspect and a sacred geographic aspect. When the U.S. Forest Service controlled the lake, the Taos Pueblo's most essential ceremony was interrupted. The return of the lake was the return of the community's sacred integrity. This is the same understanding the Whanganui iwi expressed in New Zealand when they said Ko au te awa, ko te awa ko au -- I am the river, the river is me. The lake is the people. The people are the lake.

Rain Ceremonies -- Calling Water to the Desert, Step-by-Step

The Rain Ceremony -- or more accurately, the Rain Ceremony complex -- is the most widely known Pueblo ceremonial form and the most misunderstood. It is not merely a dance asking for rain. It is a ceremony of sacred reciprocity -- the community offering their most concentrated and most sustained sacred attention to the spirit world, and the spirit world responding with the specific gift that the desert community's survival requires: water. The Rain Ceremony begins not in the plaza but in the kiva -- with days of prayer, song, and the specific preparations conducted by the medicine societies responsible for rain ceremony. Prayer sticks (pahos) are made, specific altars are constructed inside the kiva, and the ceremonial leaders conduct the restricted kiva portion of the ceremony that precedes the public plaza ceremony.

Step 1 -- The Emergence from the Kiva: At the appointed time, the dancers emerge from the kiva through the hatchway -- the emergence from below replicating the emergence of the people from the underworld.

Step 2 -- The Procession to the Plaza: The dancers process to the village plaza -- typically two lines, male dancers alternating with female dancers. The specific costumes,

specific body paint, and specific items carried are all precisely specified by the ceremony's requirements.

Step 3 -- The Dance: The dance itself -- the specific footfall patterns, the specific movements of gourd rattles, the specific body postures -- is the prayer made physical. The dancers are not performing for an audience; they are conducting a ceremony that does something specific.

Step 4 -- The Songs: The accompanying songs are performed in specific archaic sacred language maintained specifically for ceremony -- not the modern spoken form of the Pueblo language.

Step 5 -- The Cycle: Rain ceremonies typically run through multiple cycles during the day -- the dancers returning to the kiva between cycles to rest and pray, then emerging again. The ceremony may continue for one to four days.

Step 6 -- The Closing: The ceremony closes with specific prayers and the formal return of the dancers to the kiva. The ceremony's completion is understood as the fulfillment of the community's obligation -- the response is now the responsibility of the spirit world.

Corn -- The Sacred Plant of Pueblo Life

Corn (maize) is the most sacred plant in the Pueblo tradition -- simultaneously the primary food, the primary ritual offering, and the primary sacred symbol of the relationship between the Pueblo peoples and the divine forces that sustain their life in the desert Southwest. Corn pollen (the most sacred Pueblo offering substance, used in virtually every ceremony) is the most direct material expression of this sacred relationship. The color of corn -- white, yellow, blue, red, black, and multi-colored -- corresponds to the sacred directions and carries specific ceremonial meanings in different ceremonies and for different Pueblo communities.

The Corn Mother: in many Pueblo traditions, Corn is understood as a divine being -- the Corn Mother (or Corn Maiden) whose specific sacred character makes the consumption of corn a sacred communion. The first fruits restriction -- no one may eat the new corn until specific ceremonies have released it for consumption -- is the Pueblo equivalent of the Igbo's first yam restriction, the Wichita's first corn ceremony, and the Alabama-Coushatta's Green Corn ceremony: the universal principle that the new harvest belongs first to the sacred beings who produced it. Only after the sacred beings have received their portion can the human community receive theirs.

The Corn Dance (Tablita) -- Step-by-Step

The Corn Dance (also called the Tablita dance -- from the flat headdress worn by female dancers) is the most widely performed and most publicly visible Pueblo ceremony -- performed at most Pueblo communities on feast days, saint's days, and specific sacred occasions. Despite its accessibility (the Corn Dance is performed in open plazas and visitors are often welcome to observe), it is a genuine sacred ceremony, not a cultural performance.

Preparation: Dancers prepare through fasting, prayer, and specific ceremonial protocols in the kiva before the public performance.

Step 1 -- The Organization: Dancers organize into moiety groups (the Winter People and the Summer People, or their equivalent in specific Pueblo traditions) -- the specific division of the community into complementary ceremonial halves that take turns sponsoring and performing ceremonies.

Step 2 -- The Dress: Male dancers in specific body paint and specific ceremonial clothing (kilt, sash, moccasins, specific jewelry); female dancers in the tablita headdress, manta (traditional dress), and specific jewelry. Each element carries specific sacred meaning.

Step 3 -- The Dance: The specific movements -- the steady, rhythmic footfall of the men; the more subdued movements of the women -- continue for hours across multiple sets throughout the day. The drummers and singers provide the specific songs of the specific ceremony.

Step 4 -- The Offering: Specific sacred objects -- including prayer sticks (pahos) decorated with specific feathers and cornmeal -- are placed at specific locations during the dance.

Step 5 -- The Completion: The ceremony closes at a specific time with specific closing prayers and the formal end of the sacred period.

Sacred Pottery -- Vessels as Sacred Containers

Pueblo pottery is one of the most distinctive and most technically sophisticated ceramic traditions in North America -- and in the Pueblo understanding, it is not merely an art form or a craft tradition. The specific geometric patterns that characterize the pottery of each Pueblo community are visual expressions of the same sacred vocabulary that the ceremonies express in movement, song, and prayer. A San Ildefonso jar painted with specific rain cloud symbols is not decorated with rain clouds because they are pretty -- the rain cloud pattern is a prayer, a sacred statement, and a specific expression of the community's ongoing relationship with the rain-bringing spirits. The specific symbolism is community-specific: Zuni pottery's characteristic deer-with-heartline motif, Santa Clara's distinctive blackware, Acoma's geometric polychrome patterns, Taos's micaceous earthenware -- each is a specific visual sacred language. Maria Martinez (1887-1980) of San Ildefonso Pueblo is the most internationally celebrated Pueblo potter -- her revival of the matte-black-on-polished-black style in collaboration with her husband Julian created one of the most recognized ceramic traditions in the world while being entirely grounded in the specific sacred aesthetics of San Ildefonso's ceremonial life.

The Clown Societies -- Koshari and Sacred Inversion

Every Pueblo tradition maintains specific sacred clown societies -- the Koshari (in the Tewa-speaking Pueblos), the Mudheads (Koyemshi at Zuni), and various other forms in the Keresan and Hopi communities -- whose specific role is sacred inversion: the public exposure of community problems, behavioral violations, and social hypocrisy through comedic exaggeration, satirical performance, and the violation of the normal rules of public decorum. The sacred clown's license to mock, to be crude, to expose what is normally hidden, and to make the community laugh at itself is not license for general irreverence -- it is a specific sacred role that serves specific functions. By turning community failures into public spectacle (the glutton who is offered food and food and food until they are visibly ill; the lazy person who is put to very specific embarrassing work; the gossip who is addressed directly in public), the clown societies enforce community standards more effectively than any formal authority structure. The laughter that greets the clown's performance is the community acknowledging the truth of what is being shown.

Death and the Kachina Spirit World

In the Pueblo understanding, death is the transition from the living community to the Kachina spirit world -- the deceased join the Kachinas and become part of the rain-bringing sacred community that the living ceremonies address. This is why the Kachina ceremonies are simultaneously ceremonies for the living and communications with the beloved dead -- the ancestors who have become Kachinas are among the most important participants in the ceremonies that invite rain and agricultural abundance. The specific burial practices of Pueblo communities -- which include specific orientation of the body, specific grave goods, and specific ceremonial protocols -- reflect the understanding that the transition must be

properly supported for the deceased to successfully join the Kachina world. The specific protocols vary by community and are not detailed publicly.

The Haligricity Lens -- The Kiva and Sacred Community

The Pueblo tradition offers Haligricity the most complete available model of what it means for a community to maintain a specific sacred place as the living threshold between the ordinary and the sacred world, tended continuously, entered with specific protocol, and understood as the point from which the community's relationship with the spirit world is renewed through every ceremony. The kiva is the most sustained, most institutionally complete, and most architecturally specific expression of the sacred container concept in any tradition.

Every kiva maintains a sipapu -- the small hole in the floor representing the emergence point through which the ancestors came from the world below. Every ceremony conducted in the kiva is a renewal of the original emergence: the people entering the kiva descend into the below-world relationship, conduct their sacred work in that relationship, and emerge back into the ordinary world changed by what happened below. The Pueblo Revolt established that this maintenance is not negotiable: the Pueblo people expelled a colonial power that tried to interrupt it. Acoma has been on that mesa for nine hundred years -- the same houses, the same kivas, the same ceremonies. The kiva hatchway opens downward into the earth, and through it, every ceremony is a descent into the ancestor relationship and an emergence back into the ordinary world carrying what the ancestor relationship provides. The hole in the kiva floor is the hole through which all the people came. It stays open. Grand Rising.